



I saw his spirit!"

- Martin, village idiot: "Old man Otto at Bountiful Heron General Store keeps complaining that there's no one to talk to about the 'R' canes. Where do you think those grow, anyway?"
- Helga, innkeeper's wife: "Silvia, the fletcher, told me yesterday she needs a certain type of wild herb, but she hasn't had the time to go get it."

These leads should point the characters toward opportunities for adventure in and around Shadowgrange.

BOUNTIFUL HERON GENERAL STORE

Bountiful Heron is the biggest trading post in Shadowgrange. Its shelves are stocked with ordinary goods and supplies. Characters can buy adventuring gear here, with the exception of items worth over 25g. (For prices, see "Adventuring Gear" in the rulebook.)

Characters in need of metal weapons or armor are pointed to The Tempered Bull, and ranged weapons or leathers inquiries are nudged towards Fleeting Fox Provisions (see their respective sections).

The owners are an old married couple, Otto and Magda Botler. They are kind to the characters, Magda often calling them "dear" or "sweetie." Otto sits behind the counter fussing over old scrolls and tomes of arcane knowledge. Magda works the counter, feebly moving over to get anything the characters ask for with trembling hands. Their feeble movements and kindness are a ruse, however. A DC 25 Wisdom (Insight) check notices that their actions aren't entirely sincere – Magda and Otto have honed their "kind old people" act for over a decade. If confronted about it, the couple tries to laugh it off, saying pretending to be feeble gets people to do things for them.

Otto and Magda are secretly two Skirsdag cultists. Magda is a **cult fanatic** (MM 345) and Otto a **mage** (MM 347). The two came to Shadowgrange to steal *Elbrus, the Binding*

Blade (APPENDIX A) from Saint Traft's Memorial. Now with the dagger in their possession, they work tirelessly to release the demon lord Withengar from the dagger. They recently made a trek outside of Shadowgrange to help perform a demon summoning ritual alongside fellow cultists (see "Explosive Summoning" in Chapter 1).

Arcane Appreciation. Otto takes special note of any character clearly showing arcane talents – casting an arcane spell, carrying an arcane spellbook, etc. Few folks around here have knowledge of the arcane, and Otto excitedly peppers the character(s) with questions about their background, studies, and goals in their pursuit of arcane knowledge. If the character is proficient with Intelligence (Arcane), allow him or her to roll an Arcane check during their talk with Otto, provided they are willing to answer his questions. On a result of 10 or higher, Otto gifts them a *scroll of comprehend languages*, saying that he hasn't had a use for it and hopes it may help the budding spellcaster; on a 15 or higher he is so impressed with the character's knowledge that he also gifts them a *scroll of burning hands* and a *scroll disguise self*.

An Innocent Gift. Otto and Magda know that *Elbrus, the Binding Blade* requires many souls to awaken Withengar. It would be very difficult to kill enough people to unleash the demon lord without blowing their cover. The adventurers arriving in town presents a unique opportunity to pass the blade off to professional killers that will surely fulfill the dagger's soul quota and unleash Withengar for them.

Otto will take any good opportunity to put *Elbrus* in the party's hands, either by initially offering to sell them it for 50 gp, or later by gifting the characters it after they aid the village in some significant way, such clearing out the mayor's house or helping the people during the zombie attack.

Elbrus takes the innocent looking form of the *Shapeshifter's Blade* (PICTURE). Otto describes it as a weapon that changes form based on the user's thoughts (which is true), and that he picked it up along his travels but never had a use for physical weapons (also true).

AWARDING EXPERIENCE POINTS

Divide 200 XP equally among the characters if a party member talks arcane magics with lonely old Otto.

THE TEMPERED BULL

Physical danger is a fact of life for Stensians, and most villagers have weapons ready to protect themselves from the creatures of darkness. Shadowgrange's forge runs hot from the crack of dawn until late into the night, smithing new weapons and repairing damaged ones.

Marcus Ritter, the head blacksmith, is busy tempering a blade, assisted by six apprentices. The black-haired,

silver-eyed man is remarkably young for his position. An exceptional smith, his apprenticeship was cut short when the previous blacksmith was found burnt to a crisp; rumor has it that he cremated his late wife and she returned to take vengeance upon him as a fiery geist. Marcus was given the position shortly after.

Characters can buy metal arms and armor here. (For prices, see "Equipment" in the rulebook.)

Quest: Blessed Silver Shortage. Marcus used to create weapons of *blessed silver* (see APPENDIX A) with the help of the late mayor, Ralph Brunn. With his death months ago, however, no one else in the village knows the holy ritual to bless the silver as the weapons are being forged. Marcus has asked for help from Thraben but has received no response. Without new *blessed silver* weapons, the village is ill-prepared to defend themselves against supernatural horrors. The blacksmith asks if any of the characters know how to perform the ritual.

A character that has proficiency in Intelligence (Religion) can attempt a DC 15 check to see if they can perfectly recall the holy ritual. If they do, the character can assist Marcus in creating a batch of blessed weapons, which takes 10 hours uninterrupted.

If they are successful, Marcus gifts the character one of the weapons as thanks. The character can choose any metal weapon (see "Weapons" in the rulebook) as their gifted *blessed silver* weapon.

Characters can purchase additional *blessed silver weapons* for the standard price of silver weapons (weapon price + 100 gp for silver). Marcus is thankful for their help, but the blacksmith cannot give his weapon stock away for free, since this is the livelihood of him and his apprentices.

AWARDING EXPERIENCE POINTS

Divide 200 XP equally among the characters if a party member helps Marcus craft blessed silver weapons.

FLEETING FOX PROVISIONS

Three sisters, a fletcher named Silvia, a bowyer named Emma, and a leatherworker named Sybille, are co-owners of this shop. They keep the village's hunters armed and protected to venture into the dangerous wilderness.

Not only do they run the shop, but these sisters are also the most talented hunters in the village. The silver-haired women move with an uncanny grace, and despite their advanced age (all in their 50's), they retain the youthful appearance of women half their age. For these reasons, the trio have earned the nickname "Moontouched Sisters."

Characters can buy ranged weapons, ammo, and leather armors here. (For prices, see "Equipment" in the rulebook.)

Quest: Find the Lotus. Silvia asks that if the party finds

themselves in the farbog to the north, to keep an eye out for a plant called Sanguine Lotus. She has a recipe that uses the plant's flower to create a healing salve called *life's blood* (see APPENDIX A). The lotus only flowers for a few weeks this time of year, and she doesn't have the time to venture out and collect them herself. She will pay gold for them, along with some of the salve.

Characters proficient in Intelligence (Nature) will be prompted to make a DC 12 Wisdom (Perception) check while traveling through the farbog in Chapter 4. On success, they'll find sanguine lotus. If they characters bring the lotus back to Silvia, she will grind the flowers into *life's blood*, giving the party two vials of it along with 50 gp.

AWARDING EXPERIENCE POINTS

Divide 200 XP equally among the characters if the party retrieves sanguine lotus for Silvia.

VISGAUD GROUNDS

The sturdiest building in Shadowgrange is this old stone house built near the village gates. Visgaud Grounds

serves as the town hall, courtroom jail, and Town Guard headquarters, housing twenty of the militia that protect the village (the rest have small cabins of their own in and around town).

Beside the building is the cathars' training grounds, where off-duty militia train on target dummies or in practice duels with wooden swords.

Captain Levi ([PICTURE](#)) (statted as a Lawful Good **thug** [MM 350]) is the leader of Shadowgrange's militia, being promoted to that position shortly after Katarina's kidnapping. A middle-aged veteran fighter trained in Elgaud Grounds in Nephalia, Levi is a strong and capable leader charged with protecting the village as best he can.

Alchemy Shop Investigation. Levi is aware that some townsfolk are concerned about the mysteriously dying hawthorn tree at the center of the abandoned alchemy shop. He considers it a nonissue and doesn't want to deal with it, arguing his time is better spent on more pressing issues, like training new recruits and other administration work. If a PC asks to investigate the shop, or if they have the deed to the shop, Levi is happy to let them check it out.



ARMORY

A small stone tower adjacent to Visgaurd Grounds, about 30 feet tall, the armory holds arms and armor for the town militia -- spears, light wooden shield, leather armor, studded leather armor, and a few old longswords and crossbows. Most of the arms have already been issued to the members of the militia.

An ancient hawthorn tree with an unusually thick trunk grows beside the armory. Villagers call it the Eldentree. The cathars maintain the tree and diligently carve the outline of stakes and spears into its trunk. In times of need, these weapons are cut out of the Eldentree, which function as weapons of *living wood* (APPENDIX A) for the next two days.

CHAPEL

Shadowgrange's chapel is the focal point of the village. Most villagers worship here several times per week, and many pass by the church on a daily basis for a blessing of safety. Mandatory tithes and payments for blessings keep the church's coffers always full.

Priestess Flora ([PICTURE](#)), a **priestess** (MM 348), oversees the day-to-day administration at the church with the help of a few lower-ranking clergy members. She is usually busy throughout the day, leading the morning and evening sermons, blessing the villagers, and performing divine rituals to reinforce Shadowgrange's protective wards. An old, oddly talkative woman, Flora stands out amongst the majority of Stensians by being outwardly warm and welcoming.

If asked about Katarina Brunn or the artifact, Flora will take the characters aside and tell them the story of what happened to the mayor's daughter -- paraphrase the information from "Background: Voldaren's Lesson," leaving out information about the artifact itself. She knows that Katarina was studying something of grave importance for the high priests, but she doesn't know what the artifact is, only that it would've been kept somewhere in the house.

Saint Traft's Memorial. Flora is happy to show Saint Traft's memorial to any inquiring character. She fondly recalls the saint's story; how he reached Sainthood in life, how even angels would fight under his command, and his heroic death single-handedly fighting cultists and the demon-lord Withengar to protect a single innocent life. (Saint Traft's entire story can be read [here](#).)

Inside this small room is Saint Traft's memorial, dimly lit by dozens of wax candles. In the middle of the room is a statue of Saint Traft. He appears as a strong, valiant middle-aged man taking a knee in prayer while steadying a greatsword in hand. Soaring above him with outstretched feathery wings is an angel in a silken gown, holding an

ornate spear high above her head as if to rally those that look up at her. A silver plaque at the base of the statue reads, "Here lies Saint Traft, champion of Avacyn, hero of Shadowgrange."

On the back wall of the room is a display case made of glass and iron, surrounded by etchings on the walls, hymns and prayers to Avacyn. Inside the case rests a bone dagger with black engravings along its blade. A small plaque on the case reads, "A hero's sacrifice: may the foul demon Withengar suffer for an eternity in this prison."

Saint Traft's restless spirit manifests throughout Stensia, protecting innocents and vanquishing fiends much as he did in life. The powerful aura of fate hanging onto the adventurers is likely to draw his attention.

The display case is locked; a DC 20 Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) is required to open it. It is watched over by Flora, who replenishes the holy wards around it and keeps a permanent *Alarm* spell cast on the case to be alerted if anyone opens it. Flora does not permit anyone to touch the dagger, explaining that it holds the bound essence of the demon lord Withengar and is not something to be tampered with.

The dagger inside is *Elbrus, the Binding Blade* -- or at least it was, until Otto and Magda Botler stole it and replaced it with a forgery (see "Bountiful Heron General Store"). It's such a convincing duplicate that Flora has never noticed the switch. The only big giveaway is that the duplicate is a mundane item, while the real thing radiates magic, something a character may notice with the *Detect Magic* spell or similar.

Quest: Saint Traft's Favor. Traft's spirit takes note of the adventurers when they visit his shrine. The spirit senses that these characters will play a pivotal role in restoring balance to the land and seeks to aid them. At some point later in the adventure of your choosing (perhaps after the siege of Chapter 3), Traft appears to one of the characters of your choice in their dream. The spirit chooses a character that pays respect at the shrine, or one that is most likely to wield a spear in battle, or that acts in a Lawful and/or Good manner. When that character next sleeps, read or paraphrase:

The spectral figure of a noble human approaches you in your dream. His blue wispy form is perpetually shifting, as if being buffeted by an unfelt breeze. The ghostly human's features matches exactly the statue of Saint Traft you saw before: it must be his spirit.

"I sense the heavy mantle of fate resting on the shoulders of you and your allies," the spirit in an oddly comforting tone, "you shall play a role in bringing balance to this world. Unfortunately, my hold on the mortal world is weak during these dark times, but I shall help you how